

PRACTITIONER HANDBOOKS · B0

The Hertfordshire Mentoring Handbook

One reference for every mentor in the Province: the principles, the people, the member's journey from first enquiry to beyond the Chair, the moments that go wrong and what to do about them, the rules that bite, and the words and letters a new Brother will hear. Compiled from the Hertfordshire mentoring library so that a Lodge Mentor, a Personal Mentor, a Master or any Brother who has a member to look after can find what he needs in one place.

Audience	Lodge Mentors, Personal Mentors, Worshipful Masters and Wardens, Almoners, Membership Officers, Secretaries, and any Brother supporting another
Issue	Issue 1 (Draft for Review), October 2026 · Produced by the Provincial Grand Mentor's office
Status	Compendium. Where another document in the library owns a topic in full, this Handbook carries the working version and names the owner-document.
Standard	Quotes the four principles verbatim from The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles; follows the Style, Terminology and Data Guide; never reveals ritual.

Foreword

If you have a Brother to look after, this book is for you. It does not matter whether you were appointed Lodge Mentor at the last Installation, asked to keep an eye on the man you proposed, or find yourself in the Chair wondering what the newest member makes of your Lodge. The job is the same: to make sure that no Brother walks alone.

Over the past year the Province has built a library of mentoring guides, each written for one reader and one moment: a short guide for Personal Mentors, a fuller one for Lodge Mentors, checklists for the nights that matter, a card of warning signs, a guide to what happens when a member drifts or moves away, and courses to go with them. This Handbook gathers the working content of all of them into one place, in one order, so that you can read it from the front or open it at the page you need tonight.

Two ideas run through every page. Freemasonry must be fun: a man who is enjoying himself attends, participates, belongs, and does not resign. And Family, Work, Masonry, in that order, always: the member managing a busy life is not disengaged, and Freemasonry must fit into his life, not demand that his life fit around it.

Thank you for the time and care you give to this work. Hertfordshire Freemasonry is stronger because of mentors like you.

Wes Pierce
Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor, Province of Hertfordshire · October 2026

> **Freemasonry must be fun.** A man who is enjoying himself attends. A man who attends participates. A man who participates belongs. And a man who belongs does not resign.

How to use this Handbook

Part One · Foundations	What mentoring is in Hertfordshire, the four principles, who does what, and the craft of a good mentoring conversation. Read once; return when something feels off.
Part Two · The journey	Stage by stage, from first enquiry to beyond the Chair. Open at the stage your Brother has reached. Each chapter ends with what to do this week.
Part Three · When it goes wrong	Warning signs, the four steps, resignation and retrieval, keeping the door open, and relocation. The pages to open the day a letter arrives.
Part Four · Learning and the Province	Supporting learning, Solomon, the Provincial support available to you, and the rhythm of a mentor's year.
Part Five · Reference	The rules every mentor should know, dress and etiquette answers, new members' questions, the glossary of words and letters, contacts and the library.

The library this Handbook draws on

Each chapter names its owner-document in the library. When a topic changes, the owner-document changes first and this Handbook follows at its next issue. Short guides and cards remain the right thing to hand to a mentor who needs one page, not a book.

A1	The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles	The one-page canon, quoted in Chapter 2.
A2	Provincial Mentoring Framework	The Provincial strategy: team, New Initiate Pathway, One Journey, reporting.
A3	Style, Terminology and Data Guide	House style, terminology, the ritual standard, data rules for mentoring records.
B1	Lodge Mentor's Guide (Issue 2) and Short Guide	The Lodge Mentor's role and year.
B2	Personal Mentor's Guide and Quick Guide	The one-to-one companion.
B6	Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide	Owner-document for Part Three.
C1, C2	Considering Freemasonry; the New Brother's Guide	Member-facing companions for stages 1 to 3.
D1 to D4	Personal Mentoring Plan; Mentor Meeting Guide; Stage Checklists; Warning Signs card	The working tools.
E1a, E2a, E6a	Lodge Mentor Essentials; Personal Mentor Course; The Chair and Beyond	Training, with the New Masons Evening.
E5	Ceremony Explained series	What each ceremony asks and means, without revealing ritual.
F1	In That Order	The book: the philosophy and the stories behind all of it.

PART ONE

Foundations

What mentoring is in Hertfordshire, the four principles that organise it, the people who carry it, and the craft of a conversation that helps.

1 The Hertfordshire way

> *Every member, in every Lodge, experiences Freemasonry as welcoming, supportive, engaging, and personally rewarding.*
> — Our vision, The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles

Mentoring in Hertfordshire is a culture, not a programme. It is older than the office that now carries its name: Freemasons have always guided each other. What the Province has done is to make that guidance deliberate, consistent and available to every member, from the first enquiry to the years beyond the Chair, so that it no longer depends on the luck of who happened to sit next to him.

Seven propositions describe the approach. Everything else in this Handbook is one of them applied to a particular moment.

Enjoyment is the floor, not the ceiling	Freemasonry must be fun. A man who enjoys his Freemasonry attends; a man who attends participates; a man who participates belongs; and a man who belongs does not resign.
Retention is an outcome, not a target	We do not retain members by design; we build a culture that prepares and supports them, and retention follows. The question is never “How do we keep members?” but “How do we make Freemasonry so rewarding that men never want to leave?”
Mentoring is a culture, not a programme	The Lodge Mentor co-ordinates; he does not do it all himself. We are all mentors to others in Freemasonry. No one is left in the corner.
The member sets the pace	No pressure: to take office, to learn ritual, to progress between degrees, or to join the Royal Arch. Information, not recruitment; timing, not inevitability; readiness, not convenience.

Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always	Honest expectation-setting begins before the interview and never stops. There should never be any surprises. A member managing a busy life is not disengaged.
The journey is lifelong and mentoring is circular	Support runs from first enquiry to beyond the Chair, and flows both ways: the mentee teaches the mentor. The risk of loss does not end at the Chair.
Help, never interrogate	The question is always “How can we help?”, never “Why aren’t you attending?”. Compassionate enquiry underpins every intervention.

> **Key principle.** Nobody is born a good mentor. The qualities that make one are developed, and they begin with an honest look at oneself: the rough ashlar is a metaphor for every Mason, at every stage, including the most experienced.

2 The four principles

The four principles below are quoted from The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles, the Province’s canonical one-page statement. Every mentoring document in Hertfordshire quotes the same text; none restates it from memory. They are on the Mentor’s Jewel and in the Guiding Principles artwork, and they are the shape of every conversation in this book.

1 PREPARE	2 GUIDE	3 SUPPORT	4 ENLIGHTEN
Ready for each stage before it happens. No surprises.	Accurate, honest, timely information. Never dependency.	Present, responsive, compassionate. “How can we help?”	Understanding, curiosity and enjoyment, for life.

PREPARE	Ensuring members are ready for each stage of their Masonic journey. This begins before interview and continues through practical preparation for ceremonies, office, and progression - ensuring members understand what to expect before it happens. There should never be any surprises.
GUIDE	Providing accurate, clear, and timely information and support. Good guidance is honest and grounded in authoritative sources. It dispels myths, answers questions openly, and helps members navigate an unfamiliar world with confidence - without creating dependency.
SUPPORT	Being present, responsive, and compassionate throughout. Support is not only practical; it is relational. Members who feel cared for and valued are far more likely to remain engaged and committed. The question is always "How can we help?" - never "Why aren't you attending?"
ENLIGHTEN	Deepening understanding, curiosity, and enjoyment of Freemasonry. Mentoring does not end with the Third Degree; it is a lifelong opportunity to help Brethren appreciate Freemasonry - its purpose, traditions and meaning - rather than simply learn information.

> **Not stages.** These four principles are not sequential stages. They apply continuously and simultaneously throughout a member's journey: from applicant to Entered Apprentice, through each degree, into the Royal Arch, into office, through the Chair and beyond it. What you Prepare an applicant for is entirely different from what you Prepare a Fellow Craft for; the principles stay constant while the content is always personal.

The Lodge Mentor co-ordinates; the Personal Mentor accompanies; but the responsibility belongs to every member of every Lodge. A Lodge that embeds these principles into its culture, not only into the work of its Lodge Mentor, is a Lodge in which members thrive and remain.

3 Who does what

Good mentoring depends on everyone knowing who does what. There are two distinct roles in the Lodge, a wider Provincial team behind them, and several other officers who each hold a piece of the work. Clarity prevents duplication and makes sure no member falls through the gaps.

The member

At the centre. His needs for information, personal contact and one-to-one support drive everything. He sets the pace; he knows a Personal Mentoring Plan is kept, what it contains, and may see it on request; and he is never made to feel monitored, inadequate or incomplete.

The Personal Mentor

One member, one-to-one. The member's guide, friend and first point of contact through the early stages of his journey, and often beyond. He is not being asked to be an expert, a teacher or a ritualist. He is being asked to be a friend: the person a new Brother can ring, text or sit next to without feeling he is bothering anyone.

His role is	■ His first point of contact for any question ■ Someone who keeps in touch between meetings ■ A listener who notices when something changes ■ His bridge to the Lodge and the Province
His role is not	■ The only person who can help him ■ A ritual coach (that is the Lodge of Instruction) ■ Someone who monitors or reports on him ■ A replacement for the Lodge Mentor, who co-ordinates

Choose him for time, temperament and the potential for friendship, not for seniority. The Proposer often makes an excellent Personal Mentor because trust already exists; but not always, and the choice is the Lodge Mentor's. Amwell Lodge's practice of considered matching, on personality, shared interests, availability and the member's particular needs, is the mature version of this.

> **Key principle.** The Personal Mentor's most important quality is not knowledge. It is genuine interest in the wellbeing and progress of the person he is supporting. He is never required to know everything, never speculates, and is glad to say "I don't know, but I'll find out."

The Lodge Mentor

The co-ordinator. He makes sure mentoring happens, and happens well; he is not the Personal Mentor to every member. He:

- Ensures every new and joining member is assigned a suitable Personal Mentor, promptly, and gives each Personal Mentor his guide
- Opens a Personal Mentoring Plan for each member under mentoring and reviews progress against it

- Keeps an overview of mentoring across the Lodge and watches for patterns
- Is the Lodge's link to the Province: the monthly call, his Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor, the quarterly picture
- Escalates concerns to the Worshipful Master or the Province when appropriate
- Keeps simple, secure records and briefs his successor
- Briefs the whole Lodge, at least once a year, on what mentoring is and why it matters

The Province recommends a sustained term, ideally three to five years. Continuity builds experience and avoids restarting the system with every change of appointment. Part of the job is to develop the man who will follow you.

The Provincial Mentoring Team

The Provincial Grand Mentor, the Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor and five Assistant Provincial Grand Mentors, one for each APGM area. Your Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor is your nearest point of contact. He will visit, ideally at Initiations, and is there to help, never to inspect. Chapter 17 describes the support available.

The other officers who hold a piece of it

Worshipful Master	Sets the tone of the Lodge for a year and owns Step 3 conversations. Hears the Lodge Mentor's report with the same weight as the Treasurer's, briefs the Lodge on mentoring once a year, and protects junior Brethren from pressure in both directions.
Almoner	Leads on welfare: health, money, bereavement and family, and on contact with non-attenders and former members. Welcomes new members jointly with the mentors. Anything touching welfare is referred to him; the mentoring record notes only "referred to Almoner".
Membership Officer	Holds the Lodge's membership picture and the pipeline of candidates. Reviews joiners and leavers with the Lodge Mentor at least annually.
Director of Ceremonies	Owns ceremony preparation and the culture of the Lodge of Instruction: how candidates are prepared practically, how juniors are drawn into ritual gently, and how the office queue is managed fairly.
Secretary	Holds the candidate timeline that mentoring hangs from, and the attendance record, shared after every meeting. Gives same-day notice of any resignation, and acknowledges receipt only.

Treasurer	Often the first to see hard evidence of disengagement. A first missed subscription earns a quiet word to the Lodge Mentor or Almoner, long before any formal process.
Royal Arch Representative	One Journey's bridge in the Lodge. Agrees with the Lodge Mentor what is said about the Royal Arch, when, and by whom.
Preceptor of the LoI	Where not the DC: agrees how new members are welcomed at LoI and how learning is paced to the member rather than the calendar.

The Mentor's Jewel

In Hertfordshire the appointment of a Lodge Mentor is marked by the presentation and explanation of the Mentor's Jewel: two chisels in saltire. The chisel is the tool of precision and of patient, deliberate work; the crossed chisels remind us that the mentor's guidance and the member's own effort are both necessary, and neither sufficient alone. The address ends with the sentence that belongs to every Brother in the room: we are all mentors to others in Freemasonry, and must take ownership of our future.

4 The mentor's craft

Good mentoring is mostly good conversation. The content changes at every stage; the craft does not. This chapter is the Mentor Meeting Guide and the skills workshop in one place.

Open questions, then silence

Begin with an open question and then listen. Do not fill the silence: count to three before speaking. He will usually fill it himself, and what he says then will be more honest than anything before it. Five questions that work:

- "What did you make of tonight?"
- "Is there anything from the ceremony you would like to talk through?"
- "How are you getting on with the Lodge of Instruction?"
- "Is there anything about Freemasonry you have been wondering about?"
- "And how are things generally? Everything alright?"

The last one matters most. Ask it, mean it, and wait for the answer. When he raises a difficulty: listen without fixing, acknowledge it, ask what would help, and be honest when you do not know. Never guess on matters of Lodge governance or Masonic practice; find out, or point him to Solomon.

The shape of a mentoring conversation

A framework, not a script. Structure matters because without it mentoring becomes reactive, addressing whatever comes up and neglecting what does not present itself. But structure ends where the person begins.

Before	Where is he in his journey; what has happened since you last spoke; what is coming up for him and for the Lodge; anything outside the Lodge that might be affecting him.
Opening	An open question, then silence. “What did you make of tonight?” “How have things been?” “What are you curious about at the moment?”
Prepare	Does he know what is coming next? If a ceremony is approaching: timing, format, general structure (never ritual detail), etiquette, dress, practicalities. Any concerns about time, cost or travel?
Guide	Has he been introduced to Solomon, the Provincial website, DAWG, the Fleet House Light Blues Club? Encouraged to visit, with company the first time? Does he understand how Lodge, Province and Grand Lodge fit together?
Support	The heart of it. Is he enjoying himself? Is anything not working? How is the balance with everything else? Does he feel welcomed and included? Watch for vagueness, deflection, or a drop in the enthusiasm of earlier conversations.
Enlighten	What questions has he been carrying? “Is there anything from your Masonry recently that you’ve found yourself thinking about afterwards?” Follow his curiosity, not your own. Open doors; never stand in front of them; never over-explain.
Closing	End with clarity: when you will next be in touch and anything either of you will do before then. Book the next contact before you part; never leave it open-ended.

The relationship matures

In the early stages, from application to the Third Degree, regular contact matters most and the mentor is largely a teacher and a guide. As the member becomes established the formal frequency can reduce while the relationship deepens: teacher becomes coach, coach becomes advisor, advisor becomes the trusted friend he rings when something is wrong. The relationship never ends; its character simply evolves. And it runs both ways: the mentee teaches the mentor, and the mentor who stops learning from his Brother has stopped mentoring.

Where your role ends

Welfare	If he tells you something that touches his health, money, family or safety, speak to the Almoner and the Lodge Mentor promptly. You are not expected to carry it alone, and he will be better served if you do not.
Ritual	Ritual is learned at the Lodge of Instruction, from the Preceptor and the DC. Encourage, accompany, reassure; do not coach what you have not been asked to coach.
Governance	Never guess. Rules on resignation, attendance, dispensations and the like are in Chapter 18; anything else, ask the Secretary or the Provincial Grand Mentor's office.
The Royal Arch	Information, not recruitment. When he shows interest, bring in the Lodge Mentor and the Royal Arch Representative; never advocate for a particular Chapter's need for members.

Confidentiality and records

- Record only what mentoring needs: contact details, key dates, milestones and brief notes of support given. The Personal Mentoring Plan is the record; the Personal Mentor's own notes are kept to a minimum and never shared beyond the Lodge Mentor
- The member knows a Plan is kept, what it contains, and may see it on request
- Welfare matters belong to the Almoner's records. The mentoring Plan notes only "referred to Almoner"
- Keep records secure, paper or digital, and do not circulate them. Disclose confidential information only where the member's interests require it or a safeguarding concern exists
- On handover, brief your successor and pass the Plans on; close and securely destroy a Plan within a defined period after a member resigns, migrates or dies

The Style, Terminology and Data Guide sets out the Province's data rules for mentoring records in full.

PART TWO

The journey

Stage by stage, from the first enquiry to the years beyond the Chair. Two rules run through every stage: there should never be any surprises, and the member sets the pace, never the calendar.

Stage	Name	Mentoring emphasis
1	Enquiry and application	Honest expectation-setting; is the Lodge right for him; costs and time stated plainly.
2	Before Initiation	Personal Mentor assigned after ballot; practical preparation; contact the day before; introductions on the night.
3	Entered Apprentice	The critical window. Contact within a day or two; a one-to-one before the next meeting; the second meeting designed, not left to chance.
4	Fellow Craft	The forgotten degree given its due: knowledge, learning, readiness for the Third, at his pace.
5	Master Mason	The beginning, not the summit: visiting, participation, the wider structure, and the highest-risk drop-out point after the Third Degree.
6	The Royal Arch: One Journey	Completion, on his timing. Never a surprise, never a sales pitch. Information from Initiation onwards; the decision his alone.
7	Into office	Readiness, not pressure, in either direction. Ritual support without fear.
8	The Chair	Preparation for the year; support through it; and preparation, from Installation day, for what follows.
9	Beyond the Chair	Purpose after office: Included, Involved, Interested. Past Masters become Personal Mentors.
A	At risk (cross-cutting)	Warning signs, the four steps, the Rule 183 window, retrieval. Part Three.
B	Relocation (cross-cutting)	Migration as a continuation of mentoring. Part Three.

5 Enquiry and application

Mentoring begins before the ballot, ideally from the moment a man first asks. The Lodge Mentor should be involved early, working with the Proposer, Seconder, Membership Officer and Secretary. A well-informed candidate makes a better long-term member; a surprised one is the first to leave.

Before the interview

- Get to know him at informal social occasions before the formal interview, so that he arrives among friends rather than strangers
- Be open about what Freemasonry is and is not: a society of friends who meet, dine, support each other and give to charity; no secrets worth the name, and nothing he will be embarrassed to tell his family or his employer
- State the practical matters plainly: the joining fee and subscription, dining costs, meeting frequency and timing, the Lodge of Instruction, the time commitment if he later takes office, and the importance of a supportive partner or family
- Make sure he has introductory literature before the ballot: the Province's Considering Freemasonry guide and the UGLE material
- Ask what draws him. Friendship, curiosity, service, tradition, a father or grandfather: the answer shapes everything the mentor does later

The interview

Thorough and honest, in both directions. He is deciding about the Lodge as much as the Lodge is deciding about him. Cover what will be asked of him, in time and money, and what he can expect in return. Include his partner where he wishes; a partner who understands the commitment is the member's strongest ally.

> **Key principle.** Is this the right Lodge for him? A man unhappy in one Lodge is often happy in another. If his circumstances, age or interests fit a neighbouring Lodge better, say so. Retrieval for the Craft matters more than recruitment to one Lodge.

6 Before Initiation, and the night itself

After the ballot

- Assign a Personal Mentor as soon as possible after election, and open his Personal Mentoring Plan
- Meet him socially, with other members, as often as practical before his Initiation; involve his partner or family where appropriate
- Prepare him for the evening: timings, what he will be asked to do, what to wear, what to bring, and the general shape of the evening, without spoiling the ceremony itself
- The small human details: comfortable trousers, reading glasses in his pocket if he needs them, cash for the alms collection and raffle
- Any adjustments confirmed discreetly through the DC and Secretary: mobility, kneeling (not obligatory), faith requirements, the Volume of the Sacred Law appropriate to him
- A draft Festive Board reply provided well in advance, for him to adapt and make his own
- Contact him the day before, or on the morning: “We’re thinking of you. Arrive early. You’ll be guided at every step.”

On the night

On arrival	■ Meet him at the door; he should never stand alone in the anteroom ■ Introduce him to the Tyler and the Junior Deacon, who will look after him during the ceremony ■ Introduce him to the Worshipful Master and DC if opportunity allows ■ Reassure: everyone in the room has done this; the ceremony is symbolic, safe and dignified
During the meeting	■ Sit as close to him as custom allows once he is admitted; quiet explanation and reassurance as events unfold ■ Someone is with him at every point he is outside the Lodge room
The Festive Board	■ Explain Masonic fire and the order of toasts before the meal; never let him struggle in front of the room ■ Seat him according to Lodge custom and never among strangers ■ Steady him before his reply; he has the draft
End of the evening	■ Congratulate him warmly and make sure others do ■ Confirm the next Lodge date and your first one-to-one: book it now ■ Present or signpost the Initiate's Guide and the Province's New Brother's Guide, without overloading him

> **Good practice.** Introduce the candidate to the Tyler and the Junior Deacon immediately before the ceremony. Both can reassure him and make sure he does not feel isolated while he is outside the Lodge.

7 The Entered Apprentice

The evening of Initiation is one of the most formative experiences of a member's Masonic life, and the weeks after it are the critical window. The role of Brother Initiate can feel very lonely: unfamiliar sights, unfamiliar language, unfamiliar people. Our task is to dispel that strangeness as quickly as possible, through warmth, explanation and genuine friendship.

The first weeks

A quick call or message within a day or two, and a proper one-to-one before the next Lodge meeting. That first meeting is critical. Relaxed, at his pace, and including:

- An open question first: "What did you make of the evening?" Then let him talk

- A review of the ceremony: what happened and, in general terms, why. The Province's First Degree Explained is written for exactly this conversation
- A chance to ask anything at all
- The test questions he will need before his Passing, and how he will be helped to learn them: at his pace, never the calendar's
- How the Lodge is organised: officers, their roles, how to recognise them, and where the Lodge sits within Province and Grand Lodge
- Etiquette: the Risings, conduct at the Festive Board, the customs of the Lodge, dress (Chapter 19)
- The charitable work of Freemasonry, and how to sign up to Solomon

His second meeting: the neglected danger point

A new Brother is treated as the hero of his Initiation, then too easily forgotten. His second meeting is often mostly business, and nobody has told him. He sits at dinner next to two men who talk across him about people he does not know. It is the moment most often left to chance, and the easiest to design.

Before	■ Contact him in the days before; confirm he is coming; answer the questions the first month has raised ■ Decode the summons together: what each item means, how to reply, dining ■ Regalia and dress checked
On the night	■ Meet him on arrival again; the anteroom is still unfamiliar ■ Practise the salute and step quietly in a side room if he wishes; make sure he has the words of any odes ■ Sit with him, or ensure a briefed Brother does; explain business items as they happen ■ If the Lodge works a higher degree, an experienced Brother retires with him and uses the time well
The Festive Board	■ Seat him with company that will draw him in; do not let established groups close around him ■ Introduce him to two or three members he has not properly met, by name and interest
Afterwards	■ Walk out with him; confirm the next contact and the next date ■ Note anything that puzzled or unsettled him and cover it at your next one-to-one

Between degrees

When the Lodge meets in a higher degree and he cannot be present, the evening is an opportunity for companionship and learning, not dead time. Meet him that

evening or at another convenient time; use it for Masonic history, the meaning of the First Degree, the structure of Freemasonry, or whatever he is curious about; make sure he is exploring Solomon; and keep in frequent, informal contact. Regular check-ins are the difference between a member who feels included and one who quietly drifts.

His first Lodge of Instruction

- Explain what it actually is: a relaxed rehearsal, officers in different seats, corrections, restarts, laughter. Unexpectedly ordinary, and that is its charm
- If there is little for an Entered Apprentice that week, say so honestly: “come anyway and I’ll introduce you to a few people”, or steer him to a better week
- Go with him, or arrange a named Brother to meet him at the door; introduce him to the Preceptor
- No pressure to take work. Attendance with the option not to perform is explicitly fine; involve him in something small if he is willing
- If he misses a week, the only right response on his return is warmth. Lol absence met with jokes or pointed remarks is a culture that loses members

The summer, and the spring Initiate

National research finds that candidates initiated between January and June are less likely to remain than those initiated between September and December, largely because the summer break interrupts their early participation. Plan deliberate summer contact and a social touchpoint for every spring Initiate. The Lodge Mentor checks it has happened.

> **Key principle.** Isolation is one of the earliest predictors of disengagement. Belonging comes before knowledge: a man who feels he has friends in the room will learn everything else in time.

8 The Fellow Craft

The Second Degree is sometimes called the forgotten degree, a corridor between the First and the Third. It should not be. Its themes, knowledge, reason and the liberal arts and sciences, are the ones most easily connected to a member’s everyday life, and the Passing is the first time he answers in open Lodge.

Before his Passing

- Test questions learned at his pace; rehearse together until he is comfortable, never rushed to fit the Lodge calendar
- Explain the tradition: he is tested on competence before advancement, and the questions are also a chance to discuss what the First Degree meant
- Timing, format and general structure of the ceremony, never ritual detail; reassure him that everyone finds answering in open Lodge daunting and rehearsal is the antidote
- Contact him the day before; meet him on arrival; re-introduce the Tyler, Inner Guard and Junior Deacon

After his Passing

- Meet within days: “What did you make of it?” Let him talk first
- Talk through the differences he will have noticed between his Initiation and his Passing, and why they exist; the Province’s Second Degree Explained is the companion
- Discuss the liberal arts and sciences and their relevance to everyday life
- Make sure he can give the Sign, Token and Word of a Fellow Craft correctly, as taught in the Lodge; explain the different aprons
- Present and review the Fellow Craft’s Guide; encourage visiting, which he may now do freely
- Begin preparing him for the Third Degree, including the test questions, at his pace

> **Good practice.** Arrange for the Fellow Craft to witness a Passing in another Lodge as soon as convenient, and offer to go with him. Seeing the ceremony from the outside deepens understanding enormously.

> **Key principle.** Readiness, not convenience. If he is not ready to be passed, the right response is to wait and to fill the time well. What he will remember of a rushed ceremony is not the ceremony; it is the anxiety.

9 The Master Mason

The Raising is the most significant of the three degrees and a milestone, but it is a beginning, not a summit. The months after the Third Degree are one of the two

recognised drop-out windows: the visible journey seems complete, the ceremonies have stopped, and nobody has shown him the road ahead. Mentoring intensifies here; it does not fade.

Before his Raising

- Test questions rehearsed and comfortable
- Prepare him practically: timing, format, general structure; advise him to arrive well rested and having eaten
- Prepare him honestly for the ceremony's weight: it is powerful, unlike what has come before, and entirely symbolic, safe and dignified

After his Raising

- Check in within days; the reflective conversation matters more here than after any other degree. The central teaching, mortality, integrity and the life well lived, at his pace; the Province's Third Degree Explained is the companion
- Make sure he can give the Grip and the Five Points of Fellowship correctly, as taught in the Lodge
- Visiting: how to sign in, the caution needed in Lodges under other Constitutions, respect for other Lodges' workings (observe before judging; never criticise), the Visitors' Toast and thanking hosts promptly
- The structure of Grand Lodge and Provincial Grand Lodge and their principal Rulers; the Grand Lodge Certificate, which is presented as soon as it arrives and is a passport, not for framing
- Present and review the Master Mason's Guide

The months after: show him the road ahead

- Lodge of Instruction, regularly and without obligation
- Visiting across the Province and beyond; go with him the first time
- Provincial events, the Fleet House Light Blues Club, DAWG, the Visitors' Festival and the combined Mentoring and Learning and Development evenings
- Whatever in Freemasonry interests him: history, symbolism, the story of his own Lodge, charity, a piece of ritual he would like to learn
- The Royal Arch, explained as the completion of his journey, on his timing (Chapter 10)
- Gentle, open conversations about whether and when he might like to take office. Both answers are valid

> **Key principle.** Brethren who visit other Lodges, attend Provincial events and build friendships across the Province are more confident, better informed and far more likely to stay. Watch for any dip in enthusiasm now the ceremonies have finished; the Warning Signs card has the list.

10 One Journey: the Royal Arch

At the Union of 1813 Pure Antient Masonry was declared to consist of three degrees, including the Supreme Order of the Holy Royal Arch. UGLE describes the Royal Arch as the completion of that journey and encourages Master Masons to complete it before joining other orders. Hertfordshire's approach is called One Journey. Its purpose is education and timing, never pressure. The most common failure is a Brother who reaches the Chair having never had the Royal Arch explained to him, and who then hears it as a sales pitch rather than the natural close of the path he began on his Initiation night.

Four bridging points

At Initiation	The Provincial Welcome Letter and the Personal Mentor's early conversations frame Freemasonry as a four-part journey from the start. The Royal Arch is never a surprise.
Through progression	As he is passed and raised, the mentor places each step in the wider journey, so the Royal Arch is anticipated rather than introduced cold.
Around the Third Degree	The mentor makes sure he knows UGLE's encouragement to complete the journey, and that the choice, and its timing, are his alone.
Through the Royal Arch Representative	Every Craft Lodge has one. The Lodge Mentor works with him so that information is shared, accurate and consistent, and a Brother who expresses interest is introduced to a Chapter warmly.

Two rules for the conversation

> **Timing, not inevitability.** Introduce the Royal Arch when he has consolidated his understanding of the Craft, has shown curiosity or asked questions, and has room in his life for a further commitment. Never rush it, and never assume it. There is no universal right moment; there is only the right moment for him.

> **Information, not recruitment.** Tell him clearly what the Royal Arch is, what to expect, and what the time and cost involve. Reassure him that the Craft is complete and valuable in itself. He must never be made to feel an incomplete Freemason without it, and the moment a mentor advocates for a particular Chapter's need for Companions, the mentoring relationship has been compromised.

If he proceeds

Prepare him as carefully as for his Initiation: the format, location and general structure; the different officers and titles; dress and etiquette; the additional time and cost stated honestly. Support him through the joining process, and after Exaltation check in as carefully as after his Initiation. The Province's Exaltation Explained is the companion. The Royal Arch is not the end of mentoring; it is simply the next conversation.

> **Key principle.** Members who join the Royal Arch are demonstrably more likely to stay engaged with their Craft Lodges. A Brother who sees a path ahead of him stays; one who believes he has reached the end of the road is the one most at risk.

11 Joining members, re-joiners and dual members

Not every new member is an Initiate. A Brother who joins from another Lodge arrives as an experienced Mason but a stranger to this one, and the risk is that the Lodge assumes he needs nothing. He does. He needs a friend, and he needs to learn how this Lodge works.

Joining members	■ A Personal Mentor for at least his first year, chosen as a guide to the Lodge rather than a teacher of Freemasonry ■ A Personal Mentoring Plan marked as a joining-member route; the early-degree stages do not apply ■ The things nobody thinks to explain: customs and working, dining, dress, who is who, how the Lodge communicates, the calendar ■ Ask what he wants from his membership: office, friendship, a quieter Masonic life. Do not assume, and do not press him into the progression ladder ■ If he has come from another Province, close the loop with the Provincial Grand Mentor's office so the sending Lodge knows he has landed safely ■ Introduce him at the Festive Board; he does not sit alone for his first few meetings
Re-joiners	■ A Brother returning after resignation is a success story in the making. Understand, gently, why he left and what is different now ■ Treat him as a joining member for mentoring purposes, and be alert to whatever caused the earlier loss recurring ■ Bring him up to date with changes in the Lodge, the Province and Grand Lodge practice, without fuss
Dual and multiple members	■ Watch the diary: two Lodges can each ask too much. Talk to his other Lodge Mentor where you can ■ Never let two Lodges progress him to office at the same time unless he genuinely wants it ■ Make sure he still feels he belongs here, and is not simply a visitor with a subscription

12 Into office, the Chair, and beyond it

Into progressive office

When a member is offered his first office, confirm he is genuinely ready and willing; make sure he understands the responsibilities, time commitment and ritual requirements; arrange ritual support from experienced members and make sure he knows the DC and Preceptor are on his side; support regular attendance at the Lodge of Instruction; and check in as he progresses, alert to anxiety or fading confidence. Support must be available, not assumed.

Pushed too hard	■ Office before he feels ready or confident ■ Ritual beyond his current ability ■ Progression faster than he wishes ■ The Royal Arch or other orders before the time is right ■ Anything that makes him feel inadequate, unwelcome or judged
Left waiting	■ A capable Brother years from a first office behind a long queue, or behind Past Masters who prefer to hold the offices themselves ■ A Brother never asked: to visit, to take a small piece of ritual, to help with a project ■ A Past Master with nothing to do; a joining member whose experience nobody thought to use ■ A Master Mason of several years who stopped learning because nobody offered him anything to learn

> **Key principle.** Readiness runs in both directions. A bored Brother leaves as surely as a frightened one. Talk to him about what he would like; find him a role that fits; raise the office queue with the Worshipful Master and the DC; and if the Lodge cannot offer what he needs, talk to the Province about a second Lodge. Outdated practices, sink or swim, discouraging visiting, unnecessary mystique, run counter to UGLE guidance; address them sensitively but directly.

The Master Elect and the year in the Chair

The ritual book tells a Master what to say. Nothing tells him that the culture of his Lodge is, for one year, his; that the newest member's whole impression of Freemasonry will be formed in that year; and that he is standing in both risk windows at once: his new members are in the first, and he is about to enter the second. Prepare him for the year: managing the Lodge, leading meetings, working with his officers, and looking after his own wellbeing. The Province's session The Chair and Beyond does this for Wardens and Masters together.

1	Set the tone	What he laughs at, who he sits with, how he speaks to the newest member: the Lodge copies it. One quiet word about how returning members are greeted is worth a year of retention work.
2	Hear the Lodge Mentor's report	On the Committee agenda, with the same weight as the Treasurer's: who has a mentor and a Plan, who has been missed, what the Lodge could change.
3	Brief the Lodge on mentoring	Once in the year, in open Lodge. The Lodge Mentor has the presentation. We are all mentors to others.
4	Protect juniors from pressure	No office before ready; no ritual beyond ability; no Chapter sales pitch at the bar. And no capable man left waiting. The Master owns the office queue with the DC.
5	Own the Step 3 conversation	When a member is drifting and the matter touches Lodge culture, office or another member, the Master has the conversation, with the Almoner alongside for welfare.

Family, Work, Masonry applies to the Master too. The year in the Chair is the point at which a Lodge is most likely to ask too much of one man. The Master who delegates, who lets the Wardens and the DC carry their share, and who protects his own family and work, finishes the year wanting more Freemasonry, not less. The one who does not is the one the Lodge loses in the year after.

Beyond the Chair

Constitutionally, the Immediate Past Master is not an officer of the Lodge: the year after the Chair comes with a seat and no role, unless the Lodge gives him one. A seat is not a purpose. The Immediate Past Master's year decides whether a Lodge keeps its Past Masters.

Included	A seat, yes, and a voice: on the Committee, at the Lodge of Instruction, at the planning of the next year.
Involved	A role or a project: the archive, the social calendar, a ceremony to work, a Brother to mentor. Agreed before Installation, not after.
Interested	New questions: symbolism, history, the Royal Arch, the Province, a wider role. Welcome them, and prepare him for them.

> **Key principle.** Past Masters make the best Personal Mentors because they remember what the Chair cost and what it gave. Every Brother should want others to succeed, in Freemasonry and in life. The best Lodges are those in which experienced members invest in those coming behind them. That is mentoring in its truest sense.

PART THREE

When it goes wrong

The moments when the culture is tested: when engagement fades, when a resignation letter arrives, when a Brother leaves, and when a member relocates. The owner-document is the Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide.

> *We do not retain members by design; we build a culture that prepares and supports them. Retention follows naturally.*
> — Provincial Mentoring Framework

Four principles govern everything in this Part. Retention is an outcome, not a target: nothing here is about numbers. Help, never interrogate. The pattern is the signal: risk shows as a break in an individual's own pattern, not as a low absolute level of attendance; a Brother who has always attended twice a year is content, a stalwart who stops coming is not. And retrieval is a team activity: Secretary, Treasurer, Personal Mentor, Lodge Mentor, Almoner, Worshipful Master and Province each hold a piece, and every concern has a named owner at every moment.

13 Warning signs and the four steps

Most resignations are preceded by warning signs. Noticed early and acted on warmly, they can be addressed before disengagement becomes irreversible. None of these signs alone is cause for alarm; a combination, or a persistent pattern, warrants action.

Attendance	Two or more consecutive meetings missed without explanation • habitual late arrival or early departure • attending only Installations or social events • ceasing to visit other Lodges • a summer absence that extends into autumn.
Participation	Reluctance to accept work or office • withdrawal from conversation and social interaction • missing LoI while holding office • lack of preparation where it was once a point of pride • distraction or visible unhappiness in meetings.
Communication	Unanswered calls and messages • expressed frustration, disappointment or disillusionment • repeated mention of time or money pressures • unfavourable comparison with other commitments • subscription arrears (the Treasurer sees this first).

Timing intelligence. The first two years, the months after Raising, and the year after the Chair are the recognised risk windows; contact intensifies at each. **The stated reason is often not the real reason.** "Work pressure" may mean unsuitable meeting times, a personality clash, or simple lack of enjoyment. Only a relationship of trust surfaces the real reason, which is why the Personal Mentor, not a form, is the Province's early-warning system.

The four steps: graduated, warm, and mostly invisible

Step 1	Personal Mentor: informal contact	After any unexpected absence without apology, a friendly call or message: welfare, help if needed, and to say he was missed; several Brethren asked after him. After two consecutive misses, with or without apology, contact within seven days of the second meeting. Hermes will notify the Almoner automatically; the call is still the Lodge's to make. The member's needs motivate the call, never any inconvenience to the Lodge.
Step 2	Lodge Mentor involved	Where concern persists or the cause needs more than friendship. Takes the overview, considers what the Lodge itself could change (timing, cost, culture, an office that does not fit), keeps a discreet note, and closes the loop: acts on the cause, then confirms with the member that things actually feel better.
Step 3	Worshipful Master's conversation	Where the matter touches Lodge culture, office-holding, or relations with another member: a considered private conversation, with the Almoner alongside for anything touching welfare.
Step 4	Provincial referral	Where an impartial third party gives the best chance, or where the member might thrive in a different Lodge. Contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office. Referral is a sign of responsible mentoring, not failure.

> **Key principle.** The question is always "How can we help?", never "Why aren't you attending?". The first opens a door; the second puts a man on the defensive.

14 When a resignation arrives

A resignation letter is the beginning of a conversation, not the end of one. The rules give the Lodge real time; use it.

The rules (Rule 183, Book of Constitutions, as it applies in a Hermes Province)

- **The Secretary acknowledges receipt only.** He has no power to accept a resignation on the Lodge's behalf, and his reply must not read as acceptance; it says only that the resignation will be reported to the Lodge at the next meeting

- **Same-day notifications:** Almoner, Lodge Mentor and the Provincial Office are told without delay
- **Sixty days to reconsider.** Hertfordshire uses Hermes, and under the Hermes version of the Rule the sixty-day period runs automatically from the day the Secretary receives the resignation (an email suffices) or from notification in open Lodge. No Lodge vote is needed. The period was lengthened from 21 days in 2015 precisely so that retention conversations had time to work
- **A resignation spoken at the Risings** is effective from that moment. The sixty days still run; the conversation still happens
- **Note the date.** The Secretary records exactly when he received the resignation; the window is counted from it

The retrieval conversation

Within the window, the best-placed person, Almoner, Personal Mentor, Lodge Mentor or sponsor, has an unhurried, private conversation. Its purpose is understanding, not persuasion.

- What has led to this? Listen for the real reason behind the stated one
- Is there anything the Lodge could have done differently, or could still do?
- Would a change help: reduced involvement for a season, a leave of absence, stepping back from office, a transfer to a Lodge that better fits his circumstances or age profile?
- If the cause is money or health, the Almoner leads, and the Masonic Charitable Foundation may be able to help. Resignation should never be the price of a hard year
- If he is moving away, this is migration, not loss (Chapter 15). Encourage him to remain a member until he has joined elsewhere

If he still chooses to go, part with warmth and gratitude. How a Lodge handles a departure is watched by every member who stays, and it decides whether the door feels open for a return.

After a loss: keeping the door open

A Brother who resigns from all Lodges remains a Freemason, and this need not be a permanent loss. Circumstances change back. Under Rule 127 he may attend any Lodge once as an unattached visitor, signing “unattached” with his last Lodge’s name and number; and with a view to joining he may attend one Lodge up to three times in twelve months, provided the Master confirms that purpose in writing to the Secretary. These rights do not extend to Brethren excluded or expelled, or who resigned from the Craft itself.

- The Almoner keeps in touch: a birthday card, the Provincial newsletter, invitations to social functions and White Table evenings
- He remains eligible for Masonic Charitable Foundation support; say so when he leaves, it matters
- Some of the Craft's best returners were invited back by a Lodge that simply never stopped being friendly

Lessons learned

Resist the comfortable story: "he wasn't really right for us". The Secretary's register already records the reason for every cessation of membership (Rule 146), so the Lodge holds its own exit data. Collate the real reasons across several departures and look for patterns: timing, cost, culture, a particular period, a particular office. The Lodge Mentor and Membership Officer review losses together at least annually; several resignations in a short period warrant a fuller Lodge review. Themes, anonymised and never blaming, are shared with the Provincial Mentoring Team through the normal reporting rhythm, so the Province can act on what individual Lodges cannot see.

15 Migration, escalation and reporting

> *Migration is a continuation of mentoring, not an administrative exercise.*
> — Provincial Mentoring Framework

Relocation is one of the most common causes of loss, and one of the clearest opportunities to keep a member in Freemasonry.

- **Identify early.** Mentors ask about house and job moves as a matter of course, and act on hints in conversation or changes in availability
- **Trigger the process.** Contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office, which initiates the Member Migration Process with the destination Province: introductions, visits to candidate Lodges, support until he is settled. Hermes increasingly automates the cross-Provincial notification; verify the current process with the Provincial Office
- **Keep him a member until he lands.** Encourage him to retain membership, or accept a courtesy arrangement, until he has joined his new Lodge, so his service is unbroken
- **Stay in touch until settled.** The sending Lodge's duty ends not at the county boundary but when he is happily at home in his new Lodge, and every case is followed to a conclusion

- **Hertfordshire receives migrants too.** Treat an inbound migrant as a joining member (Chapter 11) and confirm his safe arrival to the Provincial Grand Mentor's office so the loop is closed for the sending Lodge

When to escalate to the Province

When a resignation risk needs impartial help; when a welfare matter exceeds the Almoner's local means; when a dispute is entangled with the concern; when several members are affected at once; when a Lodge sees a pattern of early disengagement; when a relocation triggers migration; or when you would simply like a second opinion. Escalation is responsible mentoring. The Province exists to support Lodges, not to judge them, and all contact is treated in confidence.

Reporting

Retention and retrieval experience flows through the normal rhythm: the monthly mentoring call, quarterly returns to your Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor, and the annual report, as anonymised themes, never named cases, and never attributing blame. The Province measures the process, not the person: coverage (every new member with a named Personal Mentor), activity (contact within the canonical timings, pattern-breaks actioned within seven days), experience (the member survey) and retrieval (resignations that received a conversation within the window).

PART FOUR

Learning and the Province

How mentoring supports learning, where accurate answers live, and the Provincial support that stands behind every mentor.

16 Supporting learning

Accurate, consistent learning builds confidence and enjoyment. Inaccurate or inconsistent learning breeds confusion, frustration and disengagement. Mentoring supports two kinds.

Guided learning	What a member needs to know to take part fully and confidently: the signs, tokens and words of each degree as taught in the Lodge; test questions before progression; ritual relevant to an office; etiquette and procedure; the structure of English Freemasonry. Planned, accurate, and overseen by those with the experience to do it well. The Lodge of Instruction is its natural home, and the Lodge Mentor works with the Preceptor and DC so that LoI is welcoming to junior Brethren and not only a rehearsal for officers.
Personal learning	What the individual wishes to explore for his own curiosity and fulfilment: history and symbolism; the meaning of ceremony, regalia and ritual; the story of the Lodge itself; the Royal Arch and the rest of Pure Antient Masonry. Led by his interests, lifelong, and welcomed. Interpretation is offered with humility: different Brethren read a symbol differently, and none of them wrongly.

Learning ritual, for the member who wants to

- Little and often beats one long session; ten minutes a day, out loud
- Understand it before memorising it. Ritual that means something is remembered; ritual that is only sound is lost under pressure
- Record it and listen: in the car, on a walk. Then record yourself and listen to that
- Work with a partner who prompts, and go to the Lodge of Instruction, where the floorwork and the words come together
- Never practise where a non-Mason can see or hear signs, tokens or words, including at home

- Nerves are normal and nobody minds a prompt. What the Lodge remembers is sincerity, not perfection

Solomon and Archway

Solomon (solomon.ugle.org.uk) is UGLE's online learning platform and the primary authoritative resource for members in England. It contains accurate, UGLE-approved material for every stage: short nuggets, papers, and the Diploma for those who want a structured course. Use it alongside, never instead of, face-to-face conversation; where digital access is difficult, print from it. Archway, UGLE's developing Royal Arch resource, sits alongside it for One Journey material. Steer members away from unverified online content, speculation and material from other Masonic traditions. When in doubt, refer to Solomon or ask the Provincial Grand Mentor's office.

> **The ritual standard.** Hertfordshire mentoring documents never reveal ritual. Prepare a member for what a ceremony will ask of him practically, and let the ceremony do what it is designed to do. The Ceremony Explained series exists for the conversation afterwards. Never expose a non-Mason to signs, tokens or words.

17 The Province behind you

Induction for new Lodge Mentors	Every newly appointed Lodge Mentor is invited to Lodge Mentor Essentials, a one-hour induction covering the role, the library and how to reach the Province, and receives the Lodge Mentor's Charge.
Your Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor	One for each APGM area. Your nearest source of advice, a visitor at Initiations, and the route for your quarterly picture of mentoring in the Lodge.
Monthly mentoring call	Hosted by the Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor on the first Tuesday of the month at 7pm by Teams, open to all Lodge and Personal Mentors. Questions, shared experience and news from the Provincial team.
Personal Mentor Course	A two-hour in-person workshop for Personal Mentors: asking good questions, listening, the conversations that matter, and the scenarios that test them. Bring your Personal Mentors.

The Chair and Beyond	A one-hour session for Wardens, Masters Elect and Masters: the year through a new man's eyes, the office queue, the year after the Chair.
New Masons Evening	An evening for Brethren in their first two years: mentoring, Learning and Development, and the Fleet House Light Blues Club in one room, with takeaway cards.
Combined Mentoring and L&D meetings	Twice-yearly Provincial events for new Brethren. Encourage every new member to attend one.
The Visitors' Festival	Each year the Provincial team selects an exemplary First, Second and Third Degree ceremony for newly initiated, passed and raised Brethren to attend as visitors, seated with the Provincial Mentoring Team.
The Welcome Letter	Every new Initiate receives a personal letter from the Provincial team shortly after his Initiation, with the charge after Initiation, the odes, a Solomon nugget, an introduction to the Light Blues Club and an invitation to DAWG. Make sure the Secretary has sent the details promptly.
Mentoring and Membership Past Masters' Lodge	Meets twice a year as the formal meeting point for mentoring, membership and Learning and Development across the Province.
Mentor's Jewel	Presented, with its explanation, to every Brother appointed Lodge Mentor.
Annual Mentors Award Dinner	Lodges nominate the Brethren who quietly live the principles; the Province thanks them.
DAWG	The Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group, run by the Provincial Mentoring Team: a daily piece of Masonic interest and a community of mentors.
The mentoring library	Every document in this Handbook's list, updated at each issue and available from the Provincial Grand Mentor's office and the Provincial website.
One-to-one support	For a specific situation, a difficult conversation or simply to think aloud, contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office directly. In confidence.

The Lodge Mentor's year

Every meeting	Every candidate and new member has a Personal Mentor and a Plan. Collect the attendance record from the Secretary; pass any pattern-break to the Personal Mentor within seven days. No new or joining member dines alone.
Every month	Join the Provincial mentoring call. A short word with each Personal Mentor: how is he getting on, does he need anything. Check the DAWG.
Every quarter	Update your Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor. Review Plans with Personal Mentors. Check the office queue and the under-stretched with the WM and DC.
Before each ceremony	Work through the Stage Checklist with the Personal Mentor. Confirm the candidate has been contacted the day before.
After each ceremony	Confirm the check-in and the first one-to-one have happened. Confirm the Welcome Letter has gone (Initiations).
Installation	Prepare the Master Elect for the year and for what follows it. Speak to the outgoing Master about his next role. Confirm a Past Master or two as Personal Mentors.
Summer	Deliberate contact and a social touchpoint for every spring Initiate and Entered Apprentice.
Once a year	Brief the whole Lodge on mentoring. Review joiners and leavers with the Membership Officer. Review records, destroy what is no longer needed, and brief your likely successor. Attend the Personal Mentor Course with your team.

PART FIVE

Reference

The rules a mentor meets, the practical answers a new Brother asks for, the words and letters he will hear, and where to find everyone.

18 Rules every mentor should know

Drawn from the Book of Constitutions as set out in the PGL Hertfordshire Secretaries' Handbook and Lodge Director of Ceremonies Guide, and from UGLE's Members' Pathway papers. Nothing here is from memory; if challenged, the Handbook page is the answer. Verify at each issue.

Rule	What it says	Why a mentor cares
183 Resignation	The Secretary acknowledges receipt only; he cannot accept. In a Hermes Province the member has sixty days from receipt (or from notification in open Lodge) to withdraw his resignation.	Sixty days is the retrieval window. Same-day notice to Almoner, Lodge Mentor and Province.
127 Unattached Brethren	A Brother who has resigned from every Lodge may visit any Lodge once, and one Lodge three times in twelve months with a view to joining, if the Master confirms that purpose in writing to the Secretary.	The door stays open. The Master's signature keeps it so.
148 Arrears	Two full years in arrears and he ceases to be a member automatically; announced in open Lodge and minuted.	The Treasurer saw the first missed subscription eighteen months earlier. A quiet word then.
146 Register	The Secretary records every member's dates and the reason for every cessation of membership.	The Lodge holds its own exit data. Use it for lessons learned.

172, 173 Degrees	At least four weeks between degrees. A Degree by Request lets another Lodge pass or raise a candidate on written request from the Master and Secretary; the PGM encourages double ceremonies.	Four weeks is a minimum, not a target. A candidate kept waiting a year is a candidate at risk.
119 Quorum	Five Brethren, not counting Tyler and candidate; two members; one Installed Master. No Installed Master: the meeting is abandoned. Master absent: IPM, then senior Past Master. Master Elect absent from his Installation: postponed, held within five weeks.	What happens when the Lodge is thin on the ground, and why a small Lodge needs its Past Masters.
105a, 109 Wardens	A Warden must serve a full year, Installation to Installation, to be eligible for the Chair; invested late, he needs a dispensation.	Plan the office queue with it in mind.
107, 115 The Master	A Master may continue for a second year, proclaimed not re-installed, and receives no Past Master's jewel until he installs his successor. Not Master of two Lodges at once without dispensation.	The Chair ends when he hands it on.
Grand Lodge Certificate	Presented as soon as it arrives, or sent recorded delivery and minuted. The Secretary may not hold it back until the Brother next attends.	A passport, kept with his regalia, not framed. Make the presentation a moment.
Dispensations	Via Hermes, three weeks to three months ahead, before the summons is printed. At an emergency meeting the dispensation is read first, only its business transacted, previous minutes not confirmed, no Risings.	A special ceremony needs planning weeks ahead.
Official visits	The Deputy and Assistant Provincial Grand Masters represent themselves; anyone wearing a chain is offered the gavel. Salutations are completed before the Official Visitor enters; the first wine-taking at an Installation is with him.	What the new man sees at an Installation, explained in advance.

The IPM	The Immediate Past Master is not an officer of the Lodge.	A seat and no role unless the Lodge gives him one. Chapter 12.
Inclusion	Kneeling is not obligatory; Jewish Brethren stand covered; the candidate is consulted on the Volume of the Sacred Law and the manner of his Obligation.	Confirm adjustments discreetly, through the DC and Secretary, before the night.
White Table	Never at an Installation or Initiation; toasts without fire; Masonic business said in the meeting, not at dinner.	What to tell a partner to expect.
Two misses	Hermes notifies the Almoner automatically after two consecutive misses.	The call within seven days is still the Lodge's to make.

19 Dress, etiquette and the Festive Board

The answers a new Brother asks for most. Always check the summons first; if it says nothing different, this is the standard.

Suit and shirt	Dark lounge suit, preferably black; striped morning trousers with a black jacket are acceptable. Plain white formal shirt. Tails only for Active Provincial Officers at Provincial Grand Lodge.
Socks and shoes	Plain black socks: not navy, not patterned, not novelty. Black shoes, polished.
Black tie nights	Some Lodges dine black tie always, others only at Installation. The summons will say. Dinner jacket, smart dress shirt, black bow tie.
Tie	Provincial tie in any Hertfordshire Lodge; Club tie at FHLBC visits, Gladsmuir 1385 and Provincial Grand Lodge. Outside Hertfordshire, a plain Masonic tie.
Pins and jewels	Up to three pins is the convention; Masonic or charitable, never political. Once a Master Mason, up to three jewels: Royal Arch jewel nearest the centre line, then the Tercentenary jewel, then others.
Gloves and rings	White gloves per Lodge custom; avoid dark blue square-and-compasses gloves unless you hold Provincial or Grand rank. A ring is personal preference.
Full Dress / Undress	Applies to Provincial and Grand Officers, not to a new member. Letters after names are Provincial or Grand ranks; nobody minds being asked what theirs means.

At the Festive Board

- Light-hearted and fun, but the Lodge's rules still apply: no religion, no politics
- Jackets on, unless the Master says otherwise in summer. Phones away; a quick photo of dinner is fine, a running conversation is not
- Stand when the Director of Ceremonies stands; follow the Brother next to you. The Master alone handles the gavel
- Masonic fire follows the toasts. Hertfordshire fire is a Provincial tradition, endorsed by the Provincial Grand Master, with the caveat that its speed should not become undignified. Show him before his first dinner

Replying to a toast, in six lines

1	Start with "Worshipful Master, Distinguished Brethren, Brethren all".
2	Thank the Lodge for the meeting, the work, and the Brother who invited or looked after you.
3	Mention one thing you enjoyed. One good piece of ritual is plenty.
4	Invite them to your next meeting.
5	One to two minutes. Do not rush, and do not give a best man's speech.
6	You may move to where people can see you, but no laps of the room.

20 Questions new members ask

From the Province's poll of Brethren in their first two years, and the New Masons Evening. Answer them before they are asked.

Do I have to attend every meeting and every dinner?	You should, and you will enjoy it more if you do. If you cannot, send apologies to the Secretary. Nobody will pressure you; if anything is making it hard, tell your mentor or the Almoner. Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always.
Can I visit other Lodges?	Yes, and it is encouraged; freely once you are a Fellow Craft. Contact the Lodge Secretary, introduce yourself, and expect to reply to the Visitors' Toast. Go with your mentor the first time. Observe before judging; never criticise another Lodge's working.

What do I tell people at work?	The truth: you have joined a Lodge, you meet a few times a year, there is a dinner, and it raises a great deal for charity.
Can I post about it online?	Yes, with judgement. The Festive Board and charity events, fine; anything from inside the Lodge room, not.
Can my partner get involved?	Yes. White Table evenings invite partners to dine; Ladies Night is the Master's formal dinner each year; and partners are welcome at most social events.
When will I take office?	When you are ready and if you want to. Nobody should push you early, and nobody should leave you waiting. Talk to your mentor.
How do I learn the ritual?	At the Lodge of Instruction, with your mentor and the Preceptor, little and often. Chapter 16 has the tips. Nerves are normal; nobody minds a prompt.
What is the Royal Arch?	The completion of Pure Antient Masonry. Your Lodge's Royal Arch Representative will explain it when you are ready. Information, not recruitment; timing, not inevitability.
Taylor's or Emulation?	The two main workings in Hertfordshire. Emulation is the more relaxed; Taylor's has more floorwork. Learned one and asked to work in the other? Ask first.
Can I attend Provincial Grand Lodge?	Once you are a Master Mason.
What if I am struggling?	Say so, early, to anyone: your mentor, the Almoner, the Club. Money, time, family, confidence. The question is always "How can we help?".

Three things a new member can do this week

- Join the Fleet House Light Blues Club: fhlbc.co.uk.
- Sign up to Solomon: solomon.ugle.org.uk, starting with Welcome Apprentice.
- Message his mentor with one thing from the last meeting he wants to talk about.

21 Words and letters

Words he will hear

Lodge	The basic unit: Freemasons who meet together, with a name and a number. Elects a Master and officers each year.
Province	The Lodges of a county area under a Provincial Grand Master. Above the Province is Grand Lodge.
UGLE	The United Grand Lodge of England, Freemasons' Hall, London: the governing body for English Freemasonry.
Summons	The notice of a meeting: date, time, dress, business, and who is doing what. Read it.
Festive Board	The meal after the meeting. Toasts, Masonic fire, speeches; where friendships are made.
Masonic fire	The applause that follows a toast. Hertfordshire has its own, endorsed by the Provincial Grand Master. Show him; nobody expects him to know it.
Lodge of Instruction	The rehearsal, usually informal, run by the Preceptor. Where you learn what you saw.
Installation	The yearly meeting at which the new Master is installed and appoints his officers.
Initiation, Passing, Raising	The three ceremonies that make him an Entered Apprentice, a Fellow Craft and a Master Mason.
Apron	White for an Entered Apprentice, then light blue, then dark blue for Provincial or Grand rank. Hence "light blue".
Regalia, jewels	Apron, collar for officers, gloves. Jewels are the medals worn on the breast.
Visiting	Attending another Lodge's meeting as a guest. Encouraged from the start; freely once a Fellow Craft.
Risings	The three points near the end of a meeting when the Master rises to ask for communications and apologies.
Royal Arch, Chapter	The completion of Pure Antient Masonry. A Chapter is to the Royal Arch what a Lodge is to the Craft.
Proposer, Seconder	The two members who put his name forward.

White Table, Ladies Night	A dinner to which partners are invited; the Master's formal dinner each year.
Dispensation	Formal permission from the Provincial Grand Master to vary the usual rules: an emergency meeting, a change of date or venue.
Hermes	UGLE's membership administration system. The Secretary records attendance and ceremonies on it; it notifies the Almoner after two consecutive misses.
Solomon, Archway	UGLE's learning platform, and its Royal Arch resource.
Building Together	UGLE's current national framework. Mentoring owns its ENGAGE theme.

Letters he will see

WM, IPM	Worshipful Master; Immediate Past Master, who has just left the Chair.
SW, JW	Senior and Junior Warden: with the Master, the three principal officers.
SD, JD, IG	Senior Deacon, Junior Deacon, Inner Guard: the floor officers.
DC, ADC	Director of Ceremonies and his Assistant. Follow the DC.
Tyler	The officer outside the door; the first person he met on his Initiation night.
Bro, W Bro, VW Bro, RW Bro	Brother; Worshipful Brother (has been Master); Very and Right Worshipful for senior Grand rank.
EA, FC, MM	Entered Apprentice, Fellow Craft, Master Mason.
PM	Past Master; in Hertfordshire mentoring documents also the Personal Mentor.
LM	Lodge Mentor: co-ordinates mentoring and makes sure every new member has a Personal Mentor.
ProvGM, DepProvGM, APGM	Provincial Grand Master, his Deputy, and the Assistant Provincial Grand Masters. "PGM" is not used in Hertfordshire mentoring documents because it reads two ways.
ProvGMen, APGMen	Provincial Grand Mentor and the Assistant Provincial Grand Mentors.

VO	Visiting Officer: visits a Lodge on the Provincial Grand Master's behalf. A friend, not an inspector.
LoI, CoI	Lodge of Instruction; Chapter of Instruction.
PGL, GL	Provincial Grand Lodge; Grand Lodge. PProvSGW, PAGDC and the like are Past Provincial or Grand ranks.
FHLBC, DAWG	Fleet House Light Blues Club; the Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group.
MCF	The Masonic Charitable Foundation. A member, and a former member, remains eligible for its support.
VSL	The Volume of the Sacred Law: the book of his own faith on which a candidate takes his Obligation.
BoC	The Book of Constitutions: UGLE's rules. Chapter 18 has the ones a mentor meets.

Nobody minds being asked what their letters mean. Ask.

22 Contacts and the library

Provincial Grand Mentor	W Bro Mark Butcher, via the Provincial Office
Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor	W Bro Wes Pierce, via the Provincial Office
Mentoring email	mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk (Provincial Grand Mentor's office) · asstmentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk (Assistant Provincial Grand Mentors)
Provincial Office	Fleet House, 10 Parkway, St Albans, AL3 6PA · 01727 833061 · www.pgherts.org
Monthly mentoring call	First Tuesday of the month, 7pm, on Teams
Solomon	solomon.ugle.org.uk
Fleet House Light Blues Club	fhlbc.co.uk

This Handbook is reviewed and updated at each issue. Corrections are collected in the Corrections Register and applied at the next issue; suggestions and corrections to the Provincial Grand Mentor's office.

Revision history

Issue	Date	Author	Summary
Issue 1	October 2026	Wes Pierce	First issue. Compiled from the Lodge Mentor's Guide Issue 2, the Personal Mentor's Guide and Quick Guide, the Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide, the Mentor Meeting Guide, the Stage Checklists, the Warning Signs card, the Ceremony Explained framework, the New Masons Evening cards and the Chair and Beyond session. Rule 183 stated in its Hermes form.

Provincial Office, Fleet House, 10 Parkway, St Albans AL3 6PA · 01727 833061 · www.pgherts.org · solomon.ugle.org.uk | Companion to: The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles · Lodge Mentor's Guide · Personal Mentor's Guide · Retention, Retrieval and Migration Guide · Mentor Meeting Guide · Stage Checklists · Warning Signs card · Personal Mentoring Plan | © Provincial Grand Mentor, Province of Hertfordshire, 2026